very night of our testimony, we did telecast the tapes in a three-hour-long programme without editing out any relevant information. We also fully cooperated with the police investigation which was sadly slipshod (the police, for example, never sought the phone conversations of the MPs involved in the operation which were later obtained by *Tehelka* magazine). But, importantly, there was no cover-up—we were simply placing in the public domain whatever we had. No footage was ever hidden from any authority. Our investigating team's chief producer Rohit Khanna can vouch for this.

Advani and Kulkarni, though, were still fuming, convinced that we had held back the tapes under government pressure. The BJP even boycotted our channel for a few days. I tried to reason with Advani but knew I was fighting a losing battle. 'You have let us down under pressure from the Congress,' he said, incensed. 'You have betrayed us,' shouted Kulkarni.

The truth is, there was minimal external pressure not to show the sting. A worried Congress leader Prithviraj Chavan, who was a minister in the PMO, only called up to know if any Congressmen were on the tape and asked why we had done a 'deal' with the BJP. Others like Ahmed Patel, who had been closely involved in managing the numbers for the government during the vote, seemed just relieved to know that they weren't on any tape recording. *'Yeh BJP wale mujhe phasana chahate hain'* (The BJP wants to trap me), he claimed. Neither of them threatened me in any manner, contrary to some reports.

The only one who was really worried was Amar Singh. 'You are part of a conspiracy to destroy my career,' he told me. On the night we telecast the sting, he rang up and warned me, 'I will deal with you and Arun Jaitley for doing this to me.' Years later, at a book release function, he even accused me of being the journalist who sent him to jail. 'I will never forgive you for it,' he said angrily. I found myself in the strange situation of being condemned by everyone involved: the BJP accused me of protecting the government; the government blamed me for being hand in glove with the BJP; and Amar Singh believed I had sent him to jail.